

LONELY OUTPOST St Anthony's Church in Katchatheevu island

KATCHATHEEVU

STORM IN A FRAGILE TEACUP

By Pradip R. Sagar

Just a month and a half back, on February 23 and 24, over 4,000 Indians attended the annual St Anthony's Feast in Katchatheevu Island, with an equal number of Sri Lankan devotees also present. For the feast of the guardian saint of fishermen, the Lankans provided food, drinking water and sanitary facilities. The sudden irruption of controversy over the island and its sovereignty, involving India's top politicians on the eve of the general election, would have come as a surprise to them. Especially given the seemingly unambiguous 1974 maritime agreement between the two countries—signed by the then prime ministers of India and Sri Lanka, Indira Gandhi and Sirima R.D. Bandaranaike.

Meant to demarcate their maritime boundaries from the Palk Strait to Adam's Bridge, it put Katchatheevu—a barren 1.9 sq. km island in the Palk Strait, located about 14 nautical miles from the Indian coast at Rameswaram in Tamil Nadu and 10.5 nautical miles from North Sri Lanka—in Lankan waters. Under the agreement, Indians can visit the church in Katchatheevu on St Anthony's Day. After India thus